

Unit 6



Work smarter

Inglés Profesional





Table of Contents

- 6.1. Quantifiers
- 6.2. Modal verbs
- 6.3. Indefinite pronouns
- 6.4. The Saxon Genitive
- 6.5. The Passive Voice
- 6.6. Reported Speech



Introduction

In this unit, we will explore several key aspects that are essential for developing precise and fluent communication. We will start with quantifiers, which will help us express quantities more accurately, since the difference between countable and uncountable nouns will be taken into consideration.

Then, we will dive into modal verbs to express ability, obligation, recommendation, permission, possibility and advice. We will also look at indefinite pronouns, which are used to talk about people, objects and places in a general way.

Regarding the Saxon genitive, we will learn how to indicate possession using structures like "John's phone". Additionally, we will address the passive voice, a construction that allows us to focus attention on the action or the object, rather than the subject performing it.

Finally, we will explore reported speech, which is used to relay what someone else has said, adjusting verb tenses, pronouns, and time expressions to fit the new context. Mastering this structure will allow us to accurately communicate information from different sources.

These topics are essential for improving our understanding and expression in English and will enable us to communicate with greater flexibility and clarity.



6.1.

Quantifiers

What is a quantifier?

Quantifiers are words that are used to **indicate the quantity or amount of something**, but **without providing an exact number**. Examples of quantifiers include words like *some*, *many*, *few*, *a lot of*, *much*, etc.

Quantifiers accompany a noun, so they vary depending on whether the noun they accompany is **countable** or **uncountable**. The following table shows the quantifiers that are used with countable nouns, uncountable nouns, and those that can be used in both cases.

For countable nouns	For uncountable nouns	For both
Many	Much	Some
A few	A little	Any
Few	Little	A lot of / Lots of

When do we use these quantifiers?

- > We use **many** and **much** to indicate a big number. We use **many** with countable nouns and **much** with uncountable nouns.
 - » Many companies are implementing the use of AI.
 - » Much information is shared on social media.
- > We use **a few** and **a little** to indicate a moderate number. We use **a few** with countable nouns and **a little** with uncountable nouns.
 - » There are a few platforms focused on professional networking.
 - » A little time spent on social media can help you stay updated.
- > We use **few** and **little** to indicate a small number. We use **few** with countable nouns and **little** with uncountable nouns.
 - » Few people are aware of the privacy settings on different apps.
 - » There's little control over fake news on the internet.



- > We use **some** with both countable and uncountable nouns, typically in affirmative sentences, but we can also use it in interrogative sentences when offering or requesting something.
 - » Some documents must be read before creating a profile online.
 - » Would you like some help managing the company's social media accounts?
- > We use **any** with both countable and uncountable nouns, especially in negative sentences or in questions.
 - » There aren't any new posts today.
 - » Is there any way to automate that task?
- > We use **a lot of** or **lots of** with both countable and uncountable nouns to indicate a large quantity or amount.
 - » A lot of users spend hours scrolling through online content every day.



RECUERDA

Los quantifiers son palabras que indican la cantidad de algo sin especificar un número exacto. Se usan con sustantivos contables o incontables y varían según el tipo de sustantivo. Ejemplos incluyen *many*, *few*, *some*, *much* y *a lot of*, entre otros, y su uso depende del contexto (afirmativo, negativo o interrogativo).





6.2.

Modal verbs

What are modal verbs?

Modal verbs are auxiliary or helping verbs that express ability, possibility, necessity, permission, obligation, or advice.

They **do not change their form** according to the subject (*I can, you can, she can*, etc.) except for the modal verb "have to" (*has to, had to*) and they are **always followed by the base form** of the main verb (for example, "I should spend less time on my phone", not "I should *studying*", "I should *studies*").

Types of modal verbs

In English, modal verbs can be grouped into different categories based on their function, as the following table shows.

Category	Modal verbs	Usage	Example
Ability	can (can't), could (couldn't)	Express Ability or lack of it	She can play the piano.
Possibility	may, might, could	Express possibility or uncertainty	It might rain tomorrow.
Permission	can, may, could	Ask for or give permission	Can I go to the toilet, please?
Obligation	must, have to	Express necessity or obligation	I have to work tomorrow.
Prohibition	must not, can't	Express prohibition	You can't smoke in this area.
Advice	should, ought to	Give recommendations	You should visit a doctor.



RECUERDA

Los verbos modales son verbos auxiliares que expresan habilidad, posibilidad, necesidad, permiso, obligación o consejo. No cambian según el sujeto y siempre van seguidos por la forma base del verbo principal. Ejemplos incluyen **can, may, must, should, y could**, entre otros y se agrupan según su función, como habilidad, permiso, obligación, prohibición o consejo.



6.3.

Indefinite pronouns

Indefinite pronouns are words that refer to nonspecific people, things, or places. They are used when the **exact identity** of what we are talking about is **unknown** or **not important**. This way, they help us speak in general terms without specifying exact details. For example:

Somebody stole my Facebook account.

As mentioned before, these pronouns can refer to **people** (*someone, anyone, nobody*), **things** (*something, anything, nothing*), or **places** (*somewhere, anywhere, nowhere*).

Category	Some-	Any-	No-	Every-
People	someone, somebody	anyone, anybody	no one, nobody	everyone, everybody
Things	something	anything	nothing	everything
Places	somewhere	anywhere	nowhere	everywhere

How indefinite pronouns work

- > We use some- pronouns mainly in affirmative sentences, but they are also used in interrogative sentences only when offering or requesting something.
 - » Someone liked my post just a few seconds ago.
 - » Would you like something to drink?
- > We use any- pronouns for negative and interrogative sentences. Nevertheless, it can be used in affirmative sentence, but only with the connotation of "It doesn't matter who/which/where".
 - » I didn't find anything interesting to share today.
 - » With a smartphone, you can access your social media anywhere.
 - » Anybody can create an account on this platform for free.
- > We use no- pronouns only in affirmative sentences, so they cannot be followed by a negative verb. Sometimes, they may appear alone, as a short answer.
 - » Nobody has the right software for this task.
 - » Is there anything new on her feed? -Nothing.
- > We use every- pronouns in affirmative, negative and interrogative sentences, to refer to a whole group.
 - » Everybody can benefit from cloud storage.
 - » Social media influences everything we do nowadays.

RECUERDA

Los pronombres indefinidos se usan para referirse a personas, cosas o lugares no específicos. Se emplean según el contexto (afirmativo, negativo o interrogativo) y pueden ser **someone, anything, nothing**, entre otros.



6.4.

The Saxon Genitive

The **Saxon genitive** is a grammatical structure in English used to show possession or a relationship between two nouns. The general rule of the Saxon genitive consists in adding **'s** to the noun that owns something, as the following example shows:

John has a new phone. This is **John's new phone**.

When studying the Saxon genitive, there are some spelling rules that must be considered.

- > We add **'s** to singular nouns (even if they end in -s):
 - » The boy's personal computer was stolen last week.
 - » Ross's decision helped boost productivity.
- > We add **'s** to plural nouns not ending in -s:
 - » The children's use of social media should be monitored by parents.
- > If we have more than one owner, we add **'s** to the last name:
 - » Thomas and Walter's profiles are very popular.
- > We add only the apostrophe (') to plural nouns ending in -s:
 - » My parents' car has the newest technology.

The Saxon genitive is mainly used with **people**, **animals** and **time expressions**. In the case of objects, we normally use the alternative structure with "of".

- > The phone's speaker is broken. ✗
- > The speaker of the phone is broken. ✓

Nevertheless, when the object is **personified** or related to **institutions**, **places**, or **media**, the Saxon genitive is acceptable:

- > The company's reputation. / The reputation of the company.
- > The city's streets. / The streets of the city.
- > The newspaper's editor. / The editor of the newspaper.



RECUERDA

El genitivo sajón se usa en inglés para mostrar **posesión**, agregando **'s** al sustantivo que posee algo. Se aplica con sustantivos singulares, sustantivos plurales no terminados en -s, y para más de un propietario se añade 's al último nombre. En sustantivos plurales terminados en -s, solo se usa el **apóstrofe**. Se utiliza principalmente con personas, animales y expresiones de tiempo, mientras que con objetos se prefiere la estructura con "of".





6.5.

The Passive Voice

Before studying the passive voice, it is important to remember the difference between active and passive sentences.

- > Active sentences are those in which the **subject performs the action** described by the verb.

Tom uses many digital tools.

- > Passive sentences are those in which the **subject receives the action** described by the verb. The passive voice is used when **the focus is on the action rather than who performs it**, and it frequently has a complement called **agent**, which is introduced by the preposition "by".

Many digital tools are used by Tom.

Passive voice structure

When we want to turn from active to passive voice, the structure of the passive voice is as follows:

Subject + verb to be (in the same tense as the active voice) + verb (in participle) + agent

Mark created an account. → **Active voice**

An account was created by Mark. → **Passive voice**
(subject) + (be) + (participle) + (agent)

As can be seen, the subject of the active voice becomes the agent of the passive (always adding the preposition "by"). On the other hand, the object of the active voice becomes the subject of the passive.

Also, the verb **to be** is conjugated in the same tense as the main verb of the active voice sentence, and the main verb is conjugated in the past participle form.

Login Account

 ID

 Password

☐ Remember me

[Forgot Password?](#)



Changes in pronouns

When transforming a sentence from **active voice** to **passive voice**, pronouns often change because the **subject of the active sentence becomes the object of the passive sentence** and vice versa.

In an active sentence, the **subject** (who performs the action) typically uses a **subject pronoun** (*I, you, he, she, it, we, they*), while the **object** (who receives the action) uses an **object pronoun** (*me, you, him, her, it, us, them*).

When converting to the **passive voice**, the subject of the active sentence moves to the object position, so we must replace the subject pronoun with the corresponding object pronoun and vice versa.

The following table shows the equivalence between subject pronouns and object pronouns.

Subject pronouns	Object pronouns
I	Me
You	You
He	Him
She	Her
It	It
We	Us
They	Them



RECUERDA

La voz pasiva se usa cuando el enfoque está en la acción y no en quien la realiza. En la voz activa, el **sujeto realiza la acción**, mientras que, en la pasiva, el sujeto recibe la acción. Para convertir una oración activa en pasiva, se usa la estructura: sujeto + verbo "to be" + verbo en participio + agente (introducido por "by").



6.6.

Reported Speech

Reported speech (also called **indirect speech**) is used to report what someone else said without quoting their exact words, as opposed to direct speech, where quotation marks are used. For example:

- > **Direct speech:** She said, "I love social media."
- > **Reported speech:** She said that she loved social media.

When changing a sentence from direct to reported speech, some changes usually occur:

Verb tense changes

When turning from direct to reported speech, the verb in the original sentence generally moves one step back in time to reflect the past context. This phenomenon is known as **backshift** and occurs **only when the reporting verb** (e.g. *said*, *told*, *asked*) **is in the past**.

Remember that reporting verbs are verbs used to introduce reported speech, and they tell us how someone said something, for example *state*, *ask*, *explain*, *claim*, *tell*, *say*, etc. or what they did while speaking, like *promise*, *warn* or *suggest*, among others.

As previously stated, if the reporting verb is conjugated in past, the verb in the direct speech sentence moves one step back in time, as the following table shows:

Backshift	Examples
Present Simple → Past Simple	She said, "I like my new phone." → She said that she liked her new phone.
Present Continuous → Past Continuous	She said, "I'm using my phone." → She said that she was using her phone.
Present Perfect → Past Perfect	She said, "I've used my phone." → She said that she had used her phone.
Past Simple → Past Perfect	She said, "I used my phone." → She said that she had used her phone.
Past Continuous → Past Perfect Continuous	She said, "I was using my phone." → She said that she had been using her phone.
Past Perfect → Past Perfect	She said, "I had used my phone." → She said that she had used her phone.
Future Simple → Conditional Simple	She said, "I will use my phone." → She said that she would use her phone.
Future Perfect → Conditional Perfect	She said, "I will have used my phone." → She said that she would have used her phone.



Backshift in modal verbs

Backshift	Examples
Can → Could	He said "I can speak five languages" → He said that he could speak five languages.
Have to → Had to	She said, "I have to work tomorrow" → She said that she had to work the following day.
Must → Had to	They said, "We must study more" → They said that they had to study more.
May → Might	Sarah said, "It may rain tomorrow" → Sarah said that it might rain the following day.

Backshift in questions

When we want to use the reported speech in questions, we still apply backshift as shown in the previous tables, but we also **change the word order** to a statement format.

> **With yes/no questions:** we use "if" or "whether", for example:

» **Direct speech:** He asked, "Did she call?"

» **Reported speech:** He asked if she had called.

> **With Wh-questions:** we keep the wh-word and change the verb tense, for example:

» **Direct speech:** She asked me, "Where do you live?"

» **Reported speech:** He asked me where I lived.



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Para cambiar de estilo directo a indirecto se suele hacer un cambio en el tiempo verbal de la oración, que da un **salto atrás al pasado**, lo que en inglés se llama **backshift**. Este **backshift** sólo se hace **cuando el reporting verb está en pasado**. Por el contrario, si el reporting verb está en presente, el tiempo verbal de la oración se mantiene:

+ Reporting verb in past: He **said**, "I want a new phone"

> He said that he wanted a new phone.

+ Reporting verb in present: He **says**, "I love this song"

> He says that he loves this song.





Pronoun changes

When turning from direct speech to reported speech, pronouns often need to change to match the perspective of the new speaker. This is necessary to maintain logical consistency in the sentence. The main pronoun changes are:

- > **Subject pronoun changes:** we change subject pronouns (*I, you, he, she, it, we, they*) based on who is reporting the speech.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
He said, "I am tired."	He said that he was tired.
She said, "We love technology."	She said that they loved technology.
They said, "You are late."	They said that I was late.

- > **Object pronoun changes:** object pronouns (*me, you, him, her, us, them*) also change depending on the context.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
She said, "He helped me ."	She said that he had helped her .
He told me, "I will call you ."	He told me that he would call me .

- > **Possessive pronouns and adjectives changes:** possessive pronouns (*mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs*) and possessive adjectives (*my, your, his, her, our, their*) also change accordingly.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
She said, "This is my phone"	She said that that was her phone.
He said, "These tablets are ours "	He said that those tablets were theirs .

- > **Reflexive pronouns changes:** reflexive pronouns (*myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*) follow the same logic.

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
She said, "I hurt myself "	She said that she had hurt herself .
He said, "You should take care of yourself "	He said that I should take care of myself .

Reporting commands and requests

For commands, we use the structure told + (not) to + verb (infinitive). For example:

"Close the door!" → She told me to close the door.
 "Don't touch that!!" → He told me not to touch that.

For requests, we use the structure asked + (not) to + verb (infinitive). For example:

"Can you help me?" → She asked me to help her.
 "Please don't go" → He asked me not to go.



Time and place changes

When we change from direct speech to reported speech, time and place expressions often need to be adjusted to reflect the shift in perspective. This is especially important when the reporting verb is in the past tense.

- > **Changes in time expressions:** time expressions need to be adjusted when the reported speech refers to a different time than the original statement (direct speech).

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
Now	Then
Today	That day
Tonight	That night
Yesterday	The day before / The previous day
Tomorrow	The next day / The following day
Next (week, month, year..)	The following (week, month, year..)
Last (week, month, year..)	The previous (week, month, year..)
Ago	Before

- > **Changes in place expressions:** place expressions change depending on where the reported speech is being said, as shown in the following table:

Direct Speech	Reported Speech
Here	There
This	That
These	Those



RECUERDA

Al convertir una oración del estilo directo al indirecto, no solo es necesario modificar el tiempo verbal, sino también ajustar otros elementos, como los **pronombres** y las **expresiones de tiempo y lugar**. Estos cambios permiten que la oración se adapte correctamente a la nueva perspectiva del hablante.



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